

of the Golden Fleece. These new explorers were being prepared to sail into the new, uncharted vastness of space.

Each astronaut named his capsule and Shepard included a 7 in the name because it was the seventh one made. The other astronauts, to show their support for each other, also added a 7 in their names.

Less than a month after Yuri Gagarin's historic spaceflight, on May 5, 1961, at 9:34 am, the Freedom 7 blasted off from Cape Canaveral in Florida to take Alan Shepard into Space – became the first American and the second person ever to do so. Unlike Gagarin, though, Shepard's spacecraft wasn't completely automatic. He would thus become the first person in history to pilot a spaceship and also the first to land back on Earth in it, since Gagarin had parachuted out of it. It should be noted, however, that while Gagarin managed to get to the Earth's orbit, Shepard's flight was only sub-orbital. Soon after this, Grissom also went on a sub-orbital flight aboard the Liberty Bell 7.

On February 20, 1962, an Atlas rocket successfully carried John Glenn and the hopes of an entire nation into orbit aboard Friendship 7, a flight that ushered in a new era of space travel for America. Glenn was soon followed into orbit by colleagues Carpenter, Schirra and Cooper.

Among the original Mercury 7 astronauts, only Deke Slayton didn't make a flight due to medical reasons, but he did go on to fly in Space as part of the Apollo-Soyuz Test Project crew.

These manned space flights were accomplished with complete pilot safety and without change to the basic Mercury concepts. It was shown that man can function ably as a pilot-engineer-experimenter without undesirable reactions or deteriorations of normal body functions for periods up to 34 hours of weightless flight. The Mercury experience also helped NASA develop techniques and philosophies to insure well-trained flight and ground crews and correctly prepared space vehicles.

Going to the moon

On paper, Project Mercury was a success in proving America's ability to safely take man into space and bring him back. It also ticked several other boxes in the technological spectrum. But politically and publicly, Mercury failed to make a dent.

The Soviets had won in every aspect of space missions by being first in making an ICBM, launching Sputnik into orbit and then sending Gagarin into the great beyond before the Americans could even send their astronaut